

SCUTUM THE SHIELD

THE FIFTH-SMALLEST CONSTELLATION IN THE SKY, SCUTUM LIES IN A BRIGHT AREA OF THE MILKY WAY BETWEEN SAGITTARIUS AND THE PROMINENT STAR ALTAIR IN AQUILA.

The constellation Scutum was defined by the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius in 1684. He devised it in honour of his patron, King John III Sobiesci of Poland; its original name being Scutum Sobiescianum – Sobiesci’s Shield. Just south of the celestial equator, its brightest stars are only fourth magnitude, none are named, and two, Delta and R Scuti are interesting variables. It is, however, crossed by a bright, star-rich region of the Milky Way. This includes the Scutum Star Cloud, the brightest part of the Milky Way outside Sagittarius. The Star Cloud is home to the Wild Duck Cluster, which contains around 3,000 stars. Scutum’s brightest star is Alpha Scuti, 132 times more luminous than the Sun.

KEY DATA

Size ranking	84
Brightest stars	Alpha (α) 3.8, Beta (β) 4.2
Genitive	Scuti
Abbreviation	Sct
Highest in sky at 10pm	July–August
Fully visible	74°N–90°S



CHART 4

MAIN STARS

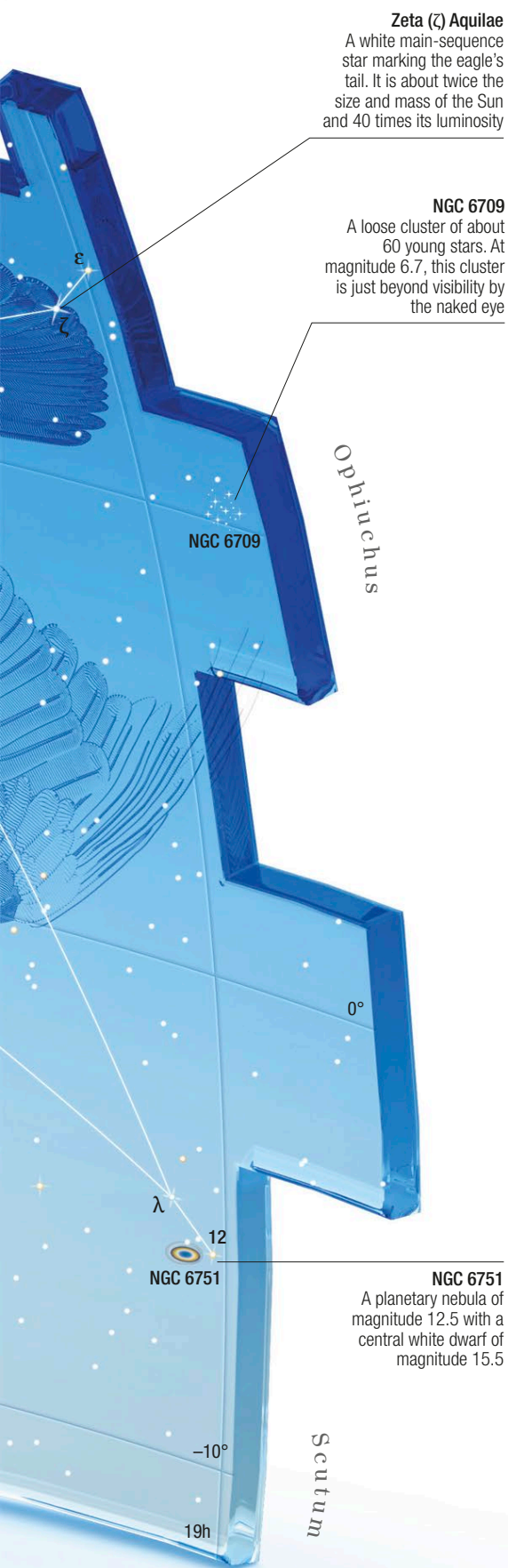
Alpha (α) Scuti	Orange giant
3.8	199 light-years

DEEP SKY OBJECTS

M11 (Wild Duck Cluster, NGC 6705)	Open star cluster
M26	Open star cluster
Scutum Star Cloud	Star-rich region of the Milky Way

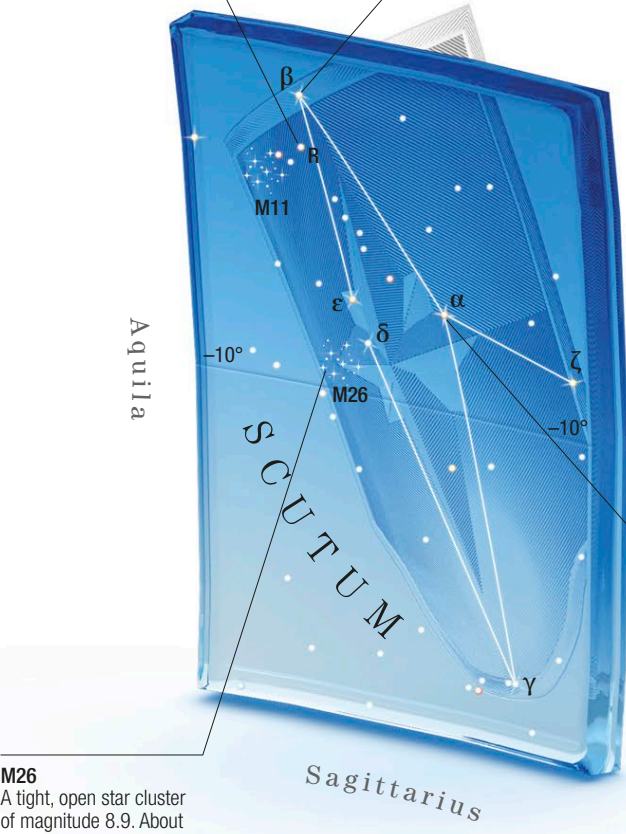


△ M11
Also known as the Wild Duck Cluster, this relatively compact open cluster of about 3,000 stars lies approximately 6,000 light-years away. About 20 light-years across and roughly 250 million years old, it is visible to the naked eye but can be seen in more detail with binoculars or a telescope.



R Scuti
This orange supergiant is a pulsating variable. It changes in magnitude from 4.5 to 8.8, in a cycle lasting 144 days

Beta (β) Scuti
A yellow giant of magnitude 4.2. It is 690 light-years away, 64 times the size of the Sun, and 1,760 times its luminosity



M26
A tight, open star cluster of magnitude 8.9. About 5,000 light-years away, its stars are 90 million years old

Alpha (α) Scuti
The brightest star in Scutum, of magnitude 3.8. This orange giant is about 21 times the width of the Sun